nineteen scrolls and fragmentary manuscripts preserve parts of the book of Genesis.[10] But many scrolls record texts that were later excluded from the Bible. For example, more than twenty scrolls and fragments preserve parts of the book of Enoch – a book allegedly written by the patriarch Enoch, the great-grandfather of Noah, and containing the history of the angels and demons as well as a prophecy about the coming of the Messiah.[11] The Jews of Qumran apparently gave great importance to both Genesis and Enoch, and did not think that Genesis was canonical while Enoch was apocryphal.[12] Indeed, to this day some Ethiopian Jewish and Christian sects consider Enoch part of their canon.[13]

Even the scrolls that record future canonical texts sometimes differ from the present-day canonical version. For example, the canonical text of Deuteronomy 32:8 says that God divided the nations of the earth according to 'the number of the sons of Israel'. The version recorded in the Dead Sea Scrolls has 'the number of the sons of God' instead, implying a rather startling notion that God has multiple sons.[14] In Deuteronomy 8:6 the canonical text requires the faithful to *fear* God, whereas the Dead Sea version asks them to *love* God.[15] Some variations are much more substantial than just a single word here or there. The Psalms scrolls contain several entire psalms that are missing from the canonical Bible (most notably Psalms 151, 154, 155).[16]

Similarly, the oldest translation of the Bible – the Greek Septuagint – completed between the third and the first centuries BCE, is different in many ways from the later canonical version.[17] It includes, for example, the books of Tobit, Judith, Sirach, Maccabees, the Wisdom of Solomon, the Psalms of Solomon and Psalm 151.[18] It also has longer versions of Daniel and Esther.[19] Its book of Jeremiah is 15 per cent shorter than the canonical version.[20] Finally, in Deuteronomy 32:8 most Septuagint manuscripts have either 'sons of God' or 'angels of God' rather than 'sons of Israel'.[21]

It took centuries of hair-splitting debates among learned Jewish sages – known as rabbis – to streamline the canonical database and to decide which of the many texts in circulation would get into the Bible as the official word of Jehovah and which would be excluded. By the time of Jesus agreement was probably reached on most of the texts, but even a century later rabbis were still arguing whether the Song of Songs should be part of the canon or